larger phenomenon of India's rise and the response of the world to it. That all 54 African states attended the IAFS Summit, that all 10 ASEAN leaders were present at the 2018 Republic Day and that India engaged 27 EU countries in Porto in 2021 and that 125 nations participated in the Voice of Global South Summit in 2023 are illustrations of where it stands today.

Often, that proposition is tested through elections to international organizations, and by and large, India has come through successfully. Indeed, the growing demand for our participation in different forums, engagement in various formats and presence on multiple occasions are reflective of our global stock.

## FINDING OUR OWN SOLUTIONS

As we come out of Covid, like every other country, India is also assessing its costs, evaluating its experiences and drawing its lessons. What can be said with some degree of confidence is that we have weathered the storm better than many others. Strong fundamentals and considered policies ensure that India stays very much on course to becoming a leading power in the future. While much of that is dependent on continuously enhancing capabilities, it is equally essential that India's vision of its prospects remain confident. After all, we have struggled with decades of downsizing, hyphenation, non-involvement and risk aversion.

The pathway for the future is built on a mindset of fierce independence, though the challenge is to refresh it for contemporary times. Our ability to express this outlook has naturally changed with our strengths. Today, we have many more resources and instruments at our command to achieve national goals abroad. But even capabilities and aspirations produce results only when filtered through an accurate understanding of the world in which we live.

A crucial aspect of diplomacy, therefore, is a comprehensive landscape analysis, which captures the contradictions and nuances so essential to make policy choices. At the highest level, it centres on multipolarity and rebalancing while taking into account the contradictions between major nations. Drilling down region by region has meant a more granular appreciation of the issues involved. In all of this, there is the overarching reality of globalization, the ideologies of which can often mislead us